Week2 choose a website

I regularly visit Reddit and Xiaohongshu (RedNote). On Reddit, the algorithm pushes a large number of relevant posts onto my homepage. This means I do not need to actively search for topics; as soon as I open the platform, I can browse content that matches my interests. Its usability mainly comes from this well-designed recommendation feed.

Similarly, RedNote tailors recommendations according to users' profiles and geographic location. It prioritises local, nearby events, which makes information spread rapidly.

In terms of areas for improvement to boost usability and visual appeal, a clean, uncluttered interface with intuitive controls is important. One strong feature on RedNote is its built-in posting templates. When users share content or start a discussion, they can use these templates: after entering their text, the platform automatically places the text over an image. This makes the text highly visible at first glance.

I think this is an effective design choice. It helps draw audience attention to the core topic, creates a harmonious mix of text and visuals, and removes the burden for users of designing their own cover images. The standard layout is straightforward: one image paired with text.

While I analysed usability on established platforms such as Reddit and Xiaohongshu from a visitor's perspective, this workshop pushed me to apply these ideas when constructing my own portfolio website. My core goal was to design a site that is intuitive and easy to navigate. Initially, I chose a gentle green-and-white palette and built upon a ready-made template, prioritising readability. Later, I decided I wanted a stronger personal aesthetic, and shifted to a dark, pixel-art style layout. Even so, I remain unsure whether this alternative design improves the overall user experience.

I kept thinking back to Xiaohongshu's strength: a unified template system creates predictable, comfortable reading experiences for its users. By comparison, my own design has exposed several unresolved usability issues. I repeatedly feel the urge to rework my base template, because it proves difficult to strike a satisfying balance between distinctive personal style, universal readability and fresh, creative expression.

My portfolio therefore stays ongoing and iterative. I frequently revise my decisions, and I rarely feel content with each completed iteration, which keeps me returning to redesign elements. Many of the starting templates I have tested are sourced from GitHub, and I appreciate the open-source community for making these resources freely available.

Deploying my site via GitHub Pages was not simple, yet it was less daunting than I had anticipated. I also find this practice thought-provoking: in the current landscape, where large corporate platforms dominate most people's online experience, creating and maintaining an independent personal website feels like a niche activity. This contrast itself has become part of my learning. At this stage, I acknowledge that there is still a great deal for me to explore and learn within web design.